

Psychology, Neuroscience & Behaviour

PSYCH 1X03

Introduction to Psychology, Neuroscience & Behaviour *Fall 2026*



SCIENCE

Instructor Information

Joe Kim

Email: intropsych@mcmaster.ca

Office Hours:

By Appointment. See link on Avenue

Michelle Cadieux

Email: intropsych@mcmaster.ca

Office Hours:

By Appointment. See link on Avenue

Course Information

This course introduces a scientific framework to explore important questions in psychology, neuroscience and behaviour. Using psychological research methods to understand learning, cognition, and social psychology, this course helps learners to develop skills to integrate, evaluate and examine information that is useful in applied settings.

Each week you will be assigned one content unit. Each unit will have 1 or 2 web modules and an assigned reading. You will also be responsible for completing an Avenue quiz associate with each topic. This course has synchronous lecture and tutorial components. Weekly quizzes will occur online through Avenue to Learn. However, both the midterm and final exam are written in-person on campus.

Course Dates: 09/08/2026 - 12/10/2026

Units: 3.00

Course Delivery Mode: Blended (In-Person/Online)

Course Description: This course introduces the scientific methods used to study the psychology of higher order processes and interpersonal behaviour. Students interested in applying to an Honours Psychology, Neuroscience & Behaviour program are encouraged to take PSYCH 1X03 rather than PSYCH 1F03. Three hours (lecture, web modules, weekly tutorials); one term Antirequisite(s): PSYCH 1F03, 1N03 It is recommended that students without Grade 12 Biology U complete BIOLOGY 1P03 prior to or concurrently with this course. Not open to students with credit or registration in ISCI 1A24 A/B or registered in B.Sc.N. Conestoga campus.

Instructor-Specific Course Information

All correspondence regarding this course should be sent to: intropsych@mcmaster.ca using your McMaster email and NOT your Avenue account.

Important Links

- [Mosaic](#)
- [Avenue to Learn](#)
- [Student Accessibility Services - Accommodations](#)
- [McMaster University Library](#)
- [eReserves](#)
- [Open Education Resources](#)

Course Learning Outcomes

- Integrate knowledge from research design, learning, cognition, and social psychology
- Apply the language of psychology in real-world settings and connect with current events
- Critically evaluate scientific information, data, and research methodologies
- Discover how psychological theories help assess, predict, or change human behaviour

Required Materials and Texts

Please sign in with your MacID [here](#) to view your booklist

Discover Psychology: MacIntroPsych Essential Readings for 1X03/1F03

Publisher: Top Hat digital textbook

Edition: 2026/2027

See Avenue for join code

MacIntroPsych Official Course Handbook 1X03/1F03

Publisher: Custom Courseware

Edition: 2026/2027

Optional but highly recommended

Class Format

Blended (In-Person/Online)

Each week you will be assigned one content unit. Each unit will have 1 or 2 web modules and an assigned reading. You will also be responsible for completing an Avenue quiz associate with each topic. This course has a synchronous lecture and tutorial component. The weekly quizzes will occur online through Avenue to learn. However, the midterm and final exam will be written in-person on campus.

During your weekly lectures you will be given the opportunity to earn bonus points by participating using the Top Hat App, which can be accesses through your smart phone, or the website interface. However, please note that both options require you to have purchased the digital textbook.

Course Evaluation

Your final grade will be automatically calculated using the best of the two weighting options.

Grading Option 1

Tutorial Participation: 10%

Avenue Quizzes - 20%

Midterm: 24%

Final Examination - 46%

Sona Research Participation (optional) - 5% - 6.5% reweight of final exam

Grading Option 2

Tutorial Participation: 10%

Avenue Quizzes - 20%

Midterm: 12%

Final Examination - 58%

Sona Research Participation (optional) - 5% - 6.5% reweight of final exam

Course Evaluation Details

Tutorial Participation (10%)

Weekly tutorials are an important part of the course and contribute to 10% of your final grade. Your TA will expect active participation to create a dynamic learning environment. If you have specific issues with this process, you must speak to the course coordinator as soon as possible.

Your TA will assign you a grade out of 10 every three tutorials based on your participation in one tutorial (5 points) and your attendance in the other two (2.5 points each). To encourage participation during all tutorials, you will not be aware of which tutorial you are being marked for participation. You will be assessed on 3 elements of participation: knowledge, insightfulness, and community.

Avenue Quizzes (20%)

There are 10 weekly online Avenue Quizzes during the semester which will cover material from the web modules, in-person lectures, and assigned readings. For example, Quiz 1 will contain material covered in the Research Methods 1 & 2 web modules and in-person lecture, as well as Chapter 1 from the textbook (The introduction chapter is not tested). Each Quiz is “open book” and you may collaborate with your peers but you may NOT post questions online. Avenue Quizzes are an opportunity to assess and consolidate your knowledge of the week’s content in preparation for the Midterm and Final Exam where you will be working independently and without access to supporting resources.

The weekly quizzes are not cumulative. Each Avenue Quiz will consist of 10 multiple-choice questions. Avenue Quizzes will be made available online every Friday at 6AM and will promptly close on Saturday at 6AM. You will have 20 minutes to complete each quiz once you open it. After closing on Saturday, the Quiz will be reviewed and grades will be released on the following Tuesday.

Quiz questions are designed to go beyond mere recall and challenge you to apply and demonstrate your comprehension. In other words, simply memorizing terms will not lead to a favourable grade. To help you prepare and assess your studying, you will have a Pre-Quiz each week (released on Monday) that will be graded immediately and will provide you with feedback on why your chosen option was correct/incorrect. You can review the completed Pre-Quiz under the Quizzes tab on Avenue. The Pre-Quiz serves as an excellent learning tool as it contains questions of the same style and difficulty as your actual Friday Quiz but does not officially count for grades. Note that the Pre-Quiz MUST be completed to gain access to the weekly Avenue Quiz.

Finally, remember that psychology is a field with a lot of emerging research, and some of it is conflicting. Since we are an introductory level course, we can only provide a snapshot of what is the most widely accepted view on each topic. As new research emerges, we update our content accordingly so that our modules reflect the current scientific consensus. As such, if you ever notice a discrepancy between your own research and what we teach in this course, you should always rely on the course information when answering questions.

Internet Problems

Internet issues can happen. We always recommend that you complete your quizzes in a location where a reliable Internet connection is guaranteed. While we do not accommodate for individual Internet issues, we can grade your quiz manually if you take screen shots. Please make sure that all photos have your name and timer in the shot.

Midterm (24%)

The midterm will be written in-person on campus on Friday November 6th at 7:30pm. It will be 30 multiple-choice questions and 1 hour long. This is a closed-book cumulative assessment. It will contain information from Research Methods, Classical and Instrumental Conditioning, Problem Solving & Intelligence, Language, Categories & Concepts, and The Science of Learning. It will cover material presented in the web modules, lectures, and assigned readings.

If you cannot write the midterm, an MSAF must be submitted to be excused from the assessment. If an MSAF is received, the weight of your midterm will be moved to your final exam.

Final Exam (46%)

A cumulative closed-book in-person Final Exam will be written in December as scheduled by the Registrar's Office. The exam will be approximately 60 multiple-choice questions and 2 hours long. If you choose to complete the Sona research participation option (see below), the weight of your final examination will be reduced from 46% to 39.5%. The Final Exam covers material presented in web modules, lectures, and assigned readings from the entire term.

Sona Research Participation Option (5% - 6.5%)

You have the option to reduce the weight of your Final Exam from 46% to 41% by completing and attaining two credits of research participation with the Department of Psychology, Neuroscience, and Behaviour. If you complete three credits you will reduce the weight of your final exam by 6.5%, making your exam

worth 39.5%. In addition to providing you with extra credit, the research participation option allows you to take part in some exciting research taking place right here at McMaster and observe how psychologists conduct their studies.

The system that the department uses to track research participation is called Sona, which can be accessed at mcmaster.sona-systems.com. To access Sona for the first time, select the "Request Account" option on the right of your screen and enter your name, student number, and McMaster email address. You will also be asked to pick your courses. Please select Psych 1X03 from the list. After a short delay, you will receive an email from Sona with a username and temporary password that you can use to access the website. You should change your password to something more memorable by selecting "My Profile". Make sure your student number is entered correctly! Note: You must activate your McMaster ID before you can create a Sona account. To activate your ID, please go to www.mcmaster.ca/uts/macid

Completing Your Research Participation Credit

When you login to Sona for the first time, you will be asked to fill out a short survey. This information is used to filter out any experiments for which you are not eligible. To register for an experiment, select "Study Sign-Up" from the main Sona page. You will be presented with a list of currently available experiments, with a short description given about each. Before selecting an experiment, be sure to read the description carefully, making special note of any specific criteria for participation (for example, some experiments only allow females to participate, while others may require participants who speak a second language). When you have found an experiment that you would like to participate in, select "View Time Slots for this Study" to view available timeslots, then select "Sign-Up" to register for a time that fits your schedule. You will receive a confirmation email with the details of your selection. Be sure to write down the study number, experimenter name, location, and telephone extension from this email.

In-Person studies: After completion of the study, you should be given a debriefing sheet explaining what the study was all about. Shortly after completing an experiment, you should notice that your Sona account has been credited by the

experimenter.

Online studies: We recommend you take a screenshot of the final completion screen as proof of your participation. You do not need to send this to anyone, it's just good to have in case something goes wrong with your credit. Credits for online studies are generally uploaded sometime after the study deadline so it may take a while for the credit to show up on Sona.

Additional Notes

- You must complete at least two credits on Sona to receive the reweight.
- If you fail to show up for two experiments, you will lose the option to sign up for new studies on Sona. If you know in advance that you will be unable to attend a scheduled experiment, please contact the experimenter as soon as possible. You can access their email by clicking on the envelope next to their name on the study information page.
- All credits must be completed by the day of the final exam (end of day).
- Please remember that your Sona participation is voluntary and that you can withdraw at any time. If you do not wish to participate as a research subject for any reason, you may still earn your research participation credit by *observing* experiments. If you would like to observe studies instead of participating, please email the course coordinator at intropsych@mcmaster.ca or visit during office hours. However, observation setup can take time and cannot be done last minute at the end of the semester.

Undergraduate Grading Scale

The grades breakdown for McMaster's 12-Point Grading Scale

Grade	Equivalent Grade Point	Equivalent Percentages
A+	12	90-100
A	11	85-89
A-	10	80-84
B+	9	77-79
B	8	73-76
B-	7	70-72
C+	6	67-69
C	5	63-66
C-	4	60-62
D+	3	57-59
D	2	53-56

Grade	Equivalent Grade Point	Equivalent Percentages
D-	1	50-52
F	0	0-49

Course Schedule

Weekly Schedule

Week of	Web Module	Textbook	Notes
Sep 7			No Lecture or Tutorial
Sept 14	Research Methods 1 and 2	Chapter 1	Quiz 1
Sept 21	Classical Conditioning	Chapter 2	Quiz 2
Sept 28	Instrumental Conditioning	Chapter 3	Quiz 3
Oct 5	Problem Solving and Intelligence	Chapter 4	Quiz 4
Oct 12	Fall Break	---	No Lecture or Tutorial
Oct 19	Language	Chapter 5	Quiz 5
Oct 26	Categories & Concepts	Chapter 6	Quiz 6
Nov 2	The Science of Learning	---	Midterm – November 6th 7:30pm
Nov 9	Attention	Chapter 7	Quiz 7
Nov 16	Memory	Chapter 8	Quiz 8
Nov 23	Forming Impressions	Chapter 9	Quiz 9
Nov 30	Influence of Others 1 and 2	Chapter 10	Quiz 10
Dec 7	---	---	Final Lecture, No Tutorial

Absences, Missed Work, Illness

McMaster Student Absence Form (MSAF): In the event of an absence for medical or other reasons, students should review and follow the Academic Regulation in the Undergraduate Calendar “Requests for Relief for Missed Academic Term Work”.

When an MSAF is submitted for a quiz, a couple of options are available depending on when it is received and when you reach out to discuss the accommodations.

1. An extension to Tuesday morning at 6am is possible if the grades have not yet been released for the quiz.
2. The quiz can be dropped, and the weight redistributed to your other quizzes.

After you have submitted your MSAF, please contact intropsych@mcmaster.ca to discuss your options.

Turnitin.com

Some courses may use a web-based service (Turnitin.com) to reveal authenticity and ownership of student submitted work. For courses using such software, students will be expected to submit their work electronically either directly to Turnitin.com or via an online learning platform (e.g. A2L, etc.) using plagiarism detection (a service supported by Turnitin.com) so it can be checked for academic dishonesty.

Students who do not wish their work to be submitted through the plagiarism detection software must inform the Instructor before the assignment is due. No penalty will be assigned to a student who does not submit work to the plagiarism detection software. All submitted work is subject to normal verification that standards of academic integrity have been upheld (e.g., on-line search, other software, etc.). For more details about McMaster's use of Turnitin.com please go to www.mcmaster.ca/academicintegrity.

Generative AI: Use Prohibited

Students are not permitted to use generative AI in this course for the submission of graded work. In alignment with [McMaster academic integrity policy](#), it "shall be an offence knowingly to ... submit academic work for assessment that was purchased or acquired from another source". This includes work created by generative AI tools. Also state in the policy is the following, "Contract Cheating is the act of "outsourcing of student work to third parties" (Lancaster & Clarke, 2016, p. 639) with or without payment." Using Generative AI tools is a form of contract cheating. Charges of academic dishonesty will be brought forward to the Office of Academic Integrity.

Checking Grades & Regrade Policy

Quiz Review

Quiz scores are released on Avenue Tuesday mornings. They can be found in the Grades section under the Assessments tab. Feedback on your quizzes is available once the grades are released. To see the feedback, go to the quiz page and scroll down to the bottom. You will see all of your past quizzes. A feedback option becomes visible next to the quiz when the grades are released. After each question you can also expand the feedback to get a more detailed reason why your answer was right or wrong. Students have one week after the quiz grades have been released to bring up any concerns related to a specific question. Please email a screenshot of the question to intropsych@mcmaster.ca. Don't forget to provide a detailed explanation of your concern.

APPROVED ADVISORY STATEMENTS

Academic Integrity

You are expected to exhibit honesty and use ethical behaviour in all aspects of the learning process. Academic credentials you earn are rooted in principles of honesty and academic integrity. **It is your responsibility to understand what constitutes academic dishonesty.**

Academic dishonesty is to knowingly act or fail to act in a way that results or could result in unearned academic credit or advantage. This behaviour can result in serious consequences, e.g. the grade of zero on an assignment, loss of credit with a notation on the transcript (notation reads: "Grade of F assigned for academic dishonesty"), and/or suspension or expulsion from the university. For information on the various types of academic dishonesty please refer to the [Academic Integrity Policy](#).

The following illustrates only three forms of academic dishonesty:

- plagiarism, e.g. the submission of work that is not one's own or for which other credit has been obtained.
- improper collaboration in group work.
- copying or using unauthorized aids in tests and examinations.

Authenticity / Plagiarism

Some courses may use a web-based service (Turnitin.com) to reveal authenticity and ownership of student submitted work. For courses using such software, students will be expected to submit their work electronically either directly to Turnitin.com or via an online learning platform (e.g. Avenue to Learn, etc.) using plagiarism detection (a service supported by Turnitin.com) so it can be checked for academic dishonesty.

Students who do not wish their work to be submitted through the plagiarism detection software must inform the Instructor before the assignment is due. No penalty will be assigned to a student who does not submit work to the plagiarism detection software. **All submitted work is subject to normal verification that standards of academic integrity have been upheld** (e.g., on-line search, other software, etc.). For more details about McMaster's use of Turnitin.com please go to www.mcmaster.ca/academicintegrity.

Courses with an On-line Element

Some courses may use on-line elements (e.g. e-mail, Avenue to Learn, LearnLink, web pages, capa, Moodle, ThinkingCap, etc.). Students should be aware that, when they access the electronic components of a course using these elements, private information such as first and last names, user names for the McMaster e-mail accounts, and program affiliation may become apparent to all other students in the same course. The available information is dependent on the technology used. Continuation in a course that uses on-line elements will be deemed consent to this disclosure. If you have any questions or concerns about such disclosure please discuss this with the course instructor.

Online Proctoring

Some courses may use online proctoring software for tests and exams. This software may require students to turn on their video camera, present identification, monitor and record their computer activities, and/or lock/restrict their browser or other applications/software during tests or exams. This software may be required to be installed before the test/exam begins.

Conduct Expectations

As a McMaster student, you have the right to experience, and the responsibility to demonstrate, respectful and dignified interactions within all of our living, learning and working communities. These expectations are described in the [Code of Student Rights & Responsibilities](#) (the “Code”). All students share the responsibility of maintaining a positive environment for the academic and personal growth of all McMaster community members, **whether in person or online.**

It is essential that students be mindful of their interactions online, as the Code remains in effect in virtual learning environments. The Code applies to any interactions that adversely affect, disrupt, or interfere with reasonable participation in University activities. Student disruptions or behaviours that interfere with university functions on online platforms (e.g. use of Avenue 2 Learn, WebEx or Zoom for delivery), will be taken very seriously and will be investigated. Outcomes may include restriction or removal of the involved students’ access to these platforms.

Academic Accommodation of Students with Disabilities

Students with disabilities who require academic accommodation must contact [Student Accessibility Services](#) (SAS) at 905-525-9140 ext. 28652 or sas@mcmaster.ca to make arrangements with a Program Coordinator. For further information, consult McMaster University’s [Academic Accommodation of Students with Disabilities](#) policy.

Requests for Relief for Missed Academic Term Work

In the event of an absence for medical or other reasons, students should review and follow the [Policy on Requests for Relief for Missed Academic Term Work](#).

Academic Accommodation for Religious, Indigenous, or Spiritual Observances (RISO)

Students requiring academic accommodation based on religious, Indigenous or spiritual observances should follow the procedures set out in the [RISO](#) policy. Students should submit their request to their Faculty Office ***normally within 10 working days*** of the beginning of term in which they anticipate a need for accommodation or to the Registrar's Office prior to their examinations. Students should also contact their instructors as soon as possible to make alternative arrangements for classes, assignments, and tests.

Copyright and Recording

Students are advised that lectures, demonstrations, performances, and any other course material provided by an instructor include copyright protected works. The Copyright Act and copyright law protect every original literary, dramatic, musical and artistic work, **including lectures** by University instructors.

The recording of lectures, tutorials, or other methods of instruction may occur during a course. Recording may be done by either the instructor for the purpose of authorized distribution, or by a student for the purpose of personal study. Students should be aware that their voice and/or image may be recorded by others during the class. Please speak with the instructor if this is a concern for you.

Extreme Circumstances

The University reserves the right to change the dates and deadlines for any or all courses in extreme circumstances (e.g., severe weather, labour disruptions, etc.).

Changes will be communicated through regular McMaster communication channels, such as McMaster Daily News, Avenue to Learn and/or McMaster email.